

Chapter 23

Art in the Age of the Enlightenment, 1750–1789

Learning Objectives

1. Discuss the ways in which Enlightenment philosophy influenced the development of architecture, painting, and sculpture in the eighteenth century.
2. Describe the impact that Enlightenment values and Classicism had on genre and portrait painting in the second half of the eighteenth century.
3. Define the qualities or characteristics of Romanticism and how they surface in the art and architecture of the second half of the eighteenth century.
4. Discuss the mix of styles or attitudes, especially Neoclassicism, Romanticism, and the Rococo, that prevailed in the second half of the eighteenth century and how elements of these different styles can appear in a single work of art.

Industrial, Intellectual, and Political Revolutions

- This was an age of revolution and radical change in society, thought, and politics with worldwide consequence.
- When the state failed to protect and facilitate the rights of the people to be freed from political shackles, the solution was to change it; this thought justified both the American and French Revolutions.
- A reverential attitude toward scientific inquiry developed that extended to studies of the natural world.
- The Industrial Revolution began to replace land-based power of the aristocracy.
- Romanticism developed as a counter to Enlightenment rationalism and explored emotions, imagination, and intuition.



John Singleton Copley THOMAS MIFFLIN AND SARAH MORRIS (MR. AND MRS. MIFFLIN)
1773. Oil on canvas, 61-5/8" x 48" (156.5 x 121.9 cm).
Philadelphia Museum of Art. © 2016. Photo Art Resource/Scala, Florence.



EUROPE AND NORTH AMERICA IN THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY

During the eighteenth century, three major artistic styles—Rococo, Neoclassicism, and Romanticism—flourished in Europe and North America.

Neoclassicism in Rome (1)

- Artists who contributed to the early Neoclassical movement were drawn to study and work in Rome.
- Cardinal Albani sponsored a villa for the purpose of displaying his vast collection of art and artifacts.
 - His librarian Johann Winckelmann became the first art historian to analyze the history of art by period styles.
- Mengs
 - Anton Raphael Mengs's *Parnassus* was the first full expression of Neoclassicism, featuring a scene from Classical mythology.
 - The pose of Apollo was copied from the *Apollo Belvedere* in the Vatican collection.



Anton Raphael Mengs PARNASSUS
Ceiling fresco in the Villa Albani, Rome. 1761.
© akg-images/Mondadori Portfolio/Sergio Anelli.

Neoclassicism in Rome (2)

- Canova
 - Antonio Canova was the leading Neoclassical sculptor of the late eighteenth century.
 - *Pauline Borghese as Venus* was an eroticized mythological sculpture originally meant for Napoleon's brother-in-law, Prince Camillo Borghese, but the recipient had it installed in a private room.



Antonio Canova CUPID AND PSYCHE
1787–1793. Marble, 61 × 68" (1.55 × 1.73 m).
Musée du Louvre, Paris. Photo © Dist. RMN-Grand Palais/Raphaël Chipault.

Neoclassicism and Early Romanticism in Britain

- Late eighteenth-century Neoclassical British artists revived civic virtue through a lens of patriotism for the British nation.
- Romanticism describes both the style and attitude of the subjective, emotional, and individual.
- Both styles existed side by side, at times without clear distinction.

The Classical Revival in Architecture and Design (1 of 5)

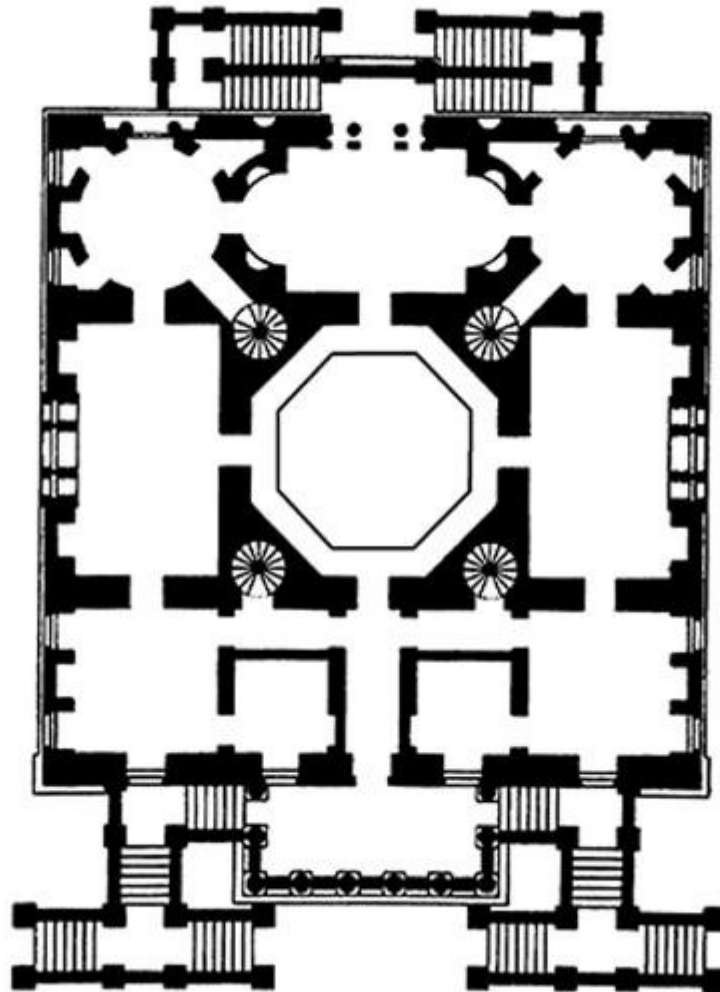
- Buildings, utensils, poetry, and fashion all gained inspiration from Classical elements.
- A group of architects led by Colen Campbell challenged the extravagance of the Italian Baroque with a return to austerity and simplicity.

The Classical Revival in Architecture and Design (2 of 5)

- Chiswick House
 - The Villa Rotunda served as inspiration for this Neo-Palladian house.
 - Richard Boyle, the third Earl of Burlington, served as designer and owner.
 - William Kent designed the grounds, utilizing the style of an English landscape garden, as well as the interior.



Richard Boyle (Lord Burlington) EXTERIOR VIEW OF CHISWICK HOUSE
West London, England. 1724–1729. Interior decoration (1726–1729) and new gardens
(1730–1740) by William Kent. © Achim Bednorz, Cologne.



Richard Boyle (Lord Burlington) PLAN OF CHISWICK HOUSE
West London, England. 1724.

The Classical Revival in Architecture and Design (3 of 5)

- Stourhead
 - Henry Hoare redesigned the grounds at Stourhead with the assistance of Henry Flitcroft.
 - The **picturesque** style was meant to mimic compositional devices of landscape painter Claude Lorrain.
 - It was intentionally contrived to look natural and unkempt.



Henry Flitcroft and Henry Hoare THE PARK AT STOURHEAD
Wiltshire, England.
Laid out 1743, executed 1744–1765, with continuing additions.
Gail Johnson/Fotolia.

The Classical Revival in Architecture and Design (4 of 5)

- Decorative Arts
 - Josiah Wedgwood was a talented chemist who developed colored **jasperware** pottery.
 - *The Apotheosis of Homer* features white figures against a blue ground.
 - The design was simplified in order to accommodate mass production as well as the idealized notions of ancient Greek art.



Josiah Wedgwood THE APOTHEOSIS OF HOMER

Made at the Wedgwood Etruria factory, Staffordshire, England. 1790–1795.

White jasperware body with a mid-blue dip and white relief, height 18" (45.7 cm).

Relief of *The Apotheosis of Homer* adapted from a plaque by John Flaxman, Jr., 1778. Trustees of the Wedgwood Museum, Barlaston, Staffordshire, England. Photo © Wedgwood Museum/WWRD.

The Classical Revival in Architecture and Design (5 of 5)

- Decorative Arts
 - He was also active in the effort to abolish slavery, evident in "Am I not a man and a brother?"
 - He commissioned a medallion for the British Committee to Abolish the Slave Trade and sent copies to Benjamin Franklin, then-president of the Philadelphia Abolition Society.



William Hackwood for Josiah Wedgwood "AM I NOT A MAN AND A BROTHER?"

1787. Black-and-white jasperware, 1-3/8" x 1-3/8" (3.5 x 3.5 cm).

Trustees of the Wedgwood Museum, Barlaston, Staffordshire, England. Photo © Wedgwood Museum/WWRD.

The Gothic Revival in Architecture and Design

- Horace Walpole's *The Castle of Otranto* was regarded as the first Gothic novel, setting the revival in motion.
 - He remodeled his country house, Strawberry Hill, into a Gothic castle.
 - The Picture Gallery inside was inspired by engravings of medieval architecture, in some places deviating to accommodate Walpole's taste.



Horace Walpole and others STRAWBERRY HILL
Twickenham, England. 1749–1776.
Photo: Robert Neuman.



Horace Walpole, John Chute, and Richard Bentley PICTURE GALLERY SHOWING
FAN-VAULTED CEILING, STRAWBERRY HILL
After 1754.
© akg-images /A.F.Kersting.

Iron as a Building Material

- The bridge over the Severn River in England was the first large-scale example of structural metal in bridge building.
- Requirements of engineering determined the form, but produced a new aesthetic that would influence cast iron works leading up to the Eiffel Tower.



Abraham Darby III SEVERN RIVER BRIDGE
Coalbrookdale, England. 1779.
© Dorling Kindersley.

Trends in British Painting (1 of 12)

- Portraits remained popular for the patrons with means to commission them.
- A taste developed for subjects that reflected the social change, embrace of natural beauty, and enthusiasm for technology that grew within Britain.

Trends in British Painting (2 of 12)

- The Satiric Spirit
 - William Hogarth invented moralizing paintings that he then turned into prints to sell as a set to the public.
 - *The Marriage à la Mode* series promoted marriage based on love.
 - *The Marriage Contract* shows a lord arranging for his son to marry the daughter of a wealthy merchant, and the betrothed couple is entirely loveless.



William Hogarth THE MARRIAGE CONTRACT
From *Marriage à la Mode*, 1743–1745.
Oil on canvas, 27-1/2" x 35-3/4" (69.9 x 90.8 cm).
National Gallery, London. © 2016. Copyright The National Gallery, London/Scala, Florence.

Trends in British Painting (3 of 12)

- The Satiric Spirit
 - Hogarth intended to create a distinctively British style without obscure mythological references.
 - Entertaining and amusing audiences while emphasizing the downfalls of the aristocracy led to the popularity of his works.

Trends in British Painting (4 of 12)

- Portraiture
 - Sir Joshua Reynolds was appointed the first president of the Royal Academy.
 - Combining his own taste for history paintings with patrons' desire for portraits, he developed the **Grand Manner** style.
 - Large scale and Classical details characterize this style.



Joshua Reynolds **LADY SARAH BUNBURY SACRIFICING TO THE GRACES**
1765. Oil on canvas, 7'10" x 5' (2.42 x 1.53 m).
The Art Institute of Chicago. Mr. and Mrs. W. W. Kimball Collection, 1922.4468.
© akq-images/De Agostini Picture Lib.

Trends in British Painting (5 of 12)

- Portraiture
 - The emphasis on setting in Thomas Gainsborough's portrait of *Robert Andrews and Frances Carter* almost turns it into a landscape painting.
 - Informal poses and natural landscapes were originally introduced by Van Dyck in the 1620s.



Thomas Gainsborough ROBERT ANDREWS AND FRANCES CARTER
(MR. AND MRS. ANDREWS)
c. 1748–1750. Oil on canvas, 27-1/2" × 47" (69.7 × 119.3 cm).
National Gallery, London. © 2016. Copyright The National Gallery, London/Scala, Florence.

Trends in British Painting (6 of 12)

- The Romance of Science
 - *An Experiment on a Bird in the Air-pump* is Joseph Wright of Derby's example of the Enlightenment fascination with the drama and romance of science.
 - In it, an experiment removed the air from a glass bowl until a bird collapsed from lack of oxygen, but the bird is quickly revived.



Joseph Wright of Derby AN EXPERIMENT ON A BIRD IN THE AIR-PUMP
1768. Oil on canvas, 6' x 8' (1.82 x 2.43 m).

National Gallery, London. © 2016. Copyright The National Gallery, London/Scala, Florence.

Trends in British Painting (7 of 12)

- Academies and Academy Exhibitions
 - **History paintings** were relegated to the highest place in the Academy's hierarchy of genres.
 - The competitive "Prix de Rome" enabled winners to study in Rome for 3–5 years.
 - Only seven women were admitted between 1648–1706, and admission was limited to four thereafter.



Johann Zoffany ACADEMICIANS OF THE ROYAL ACADEMY
1771–1772. Oil on canvas, 47-1/2" x 59-1/2" (120.6 x 151.2 cm).
The Royal Collection, Windsor Castle, England. Royal Collection Trust © Her Majesty Queen Elizabeth II, 2016/
Bridgeman Images.

Trends in British Painting (8 of 12)

- History Painting
 - Angelica Kauffmann embarked on an independent career in history painting despite the trend of women specializing in portraiture or still life.
 - *Cornelia Pointing to Her Children as Her Treasures* illustrates a moral lesson from ancient Republican Rome, and glorifies the idealized "good mother."



Angelica Kauffmann CORNELIA POINTING TO HER CHILDREN AS HER TREASURES

c. 1785. Oil on canvas, 40 × 50" (101.6 × 127 cm).

Virginia Museum of Fine Arts, Richmond, Virginia. The Adolph D. and Wilkins C. Williams Fund. Virginia Museum of Fine Arts, Richmond. Photo: Katherine Wetzel.

Trends in British Painting (9 of 12)

- History Painting
 - American-born Benjamin West broke with tradition in his *The Death of General Wolfe*.
 - It was a "modern history" painting depicting a contemporary subject in an elevated scene not meant to be perceived as an objective recording.
 - Poses suggest a Lamentation of the dead Christ.



Benjamin West THE DEATH OF GENERAL WOLFE

1770. Oil on canvas, 4'11-1/2" x 7' (1.51 x 2.14 m).

National Gallery of Canada, Ottawa. Transfer from the Canadian War Memorials, 1921. Gift of the 2nd Duke of Westminster, Eaton Hall, Cheshire, 1918. National Gallery of Canada, Ottawa.

Trends in British Painting (10 of 12)

- Romantic Painting
 - John Henry Fuseli glorified Romanticism in works such as *The Nightmare*, which was both irrational and erotic in its depiction of a sleeping woman oppressed by a demon sitting on her chest.
 - A horse bursting into the scene from the curtains adds frightening effect.



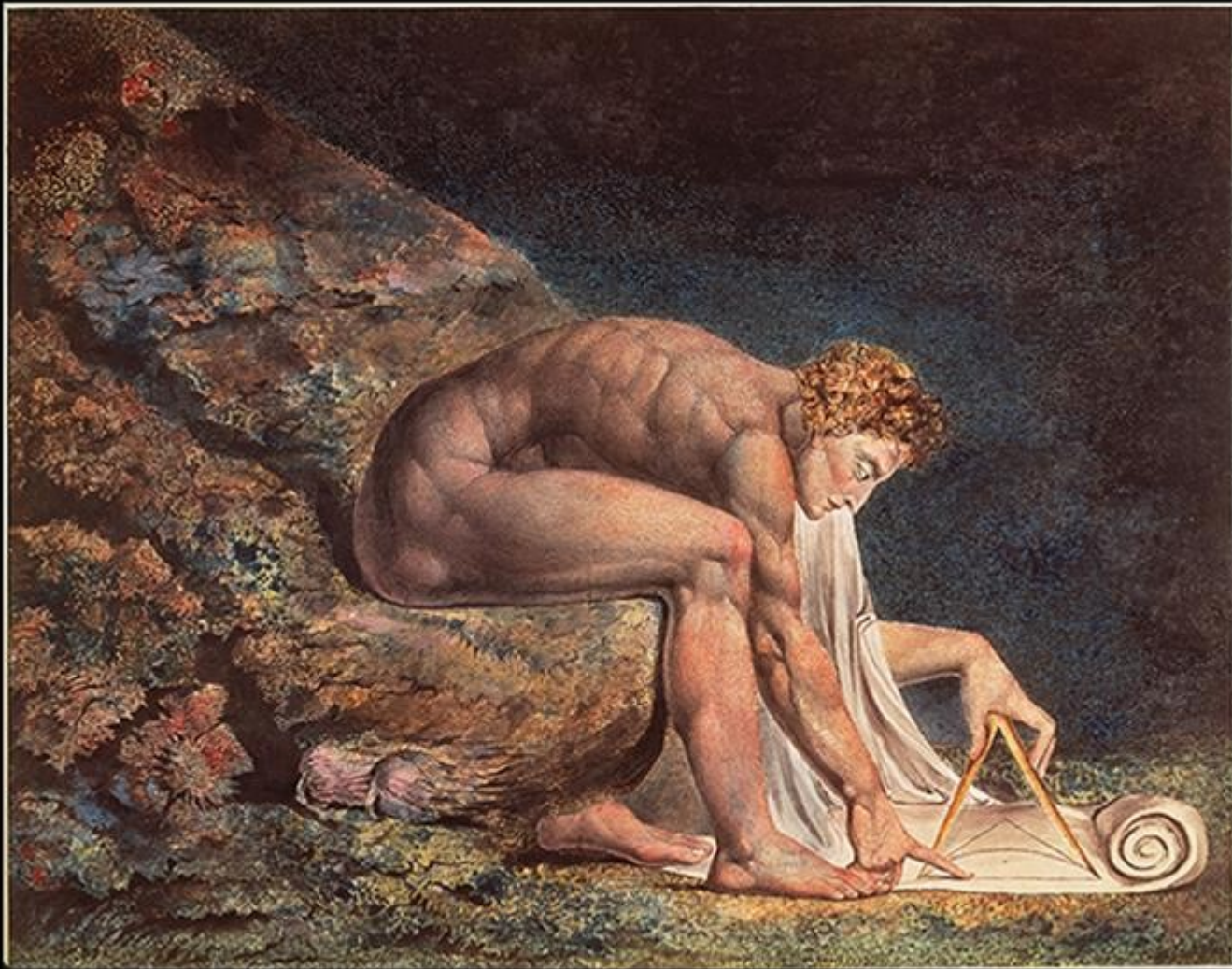
John Henry Fuseli THE NIGHTMARE

1781. Oil on canvas, 39-3/4" x 49-1/2" (101 x 127 cm).

The Detroit Institute of Arts. Founders Society purchase with Mr. and Mrs. Bert L. Smokler and Mr. and Mrs. Lawrence A. Fleischmann funds. Bridgeman Images

Trends in British Painting (11 of 12)

- Romantic Painting
 - Poet, painter, and printmaker William Blake was interested in examining the nature of good and evil.
 - The large print *Newton* was included in a series of prophetic prints and depicted the epitome of eighteenth-century rationalism.



William Blake NEWTON
1795–c. 1805.

Color print finished in ink and watercolor, 18-1/8" x 23-5/8" (46 x 60 cm).
Tate, London. Photo © Peter Willi/ARTOTHEK.

Trends in British Painting (12 of 12)

- Romantic Painting
 - John Singleton Copley became a painter of modern history.
 - *Watson and the Shark* is an example of a work with figures inspired by Classical sources, but a gruesome subject.
 - The inclusion of the African figure reflected a debate in British Parliament about the American slave trade; it could indicate Watson's sympathy for slaves.



John Singleton Copley **WATSON AND THE SHARK**
1778. Oil on canvas, 5'10-3/4" x 7'6-1/2" (1.82 x 2.29 m).
National Gallery of Art, Washington, DC. Ferdinand Lammot Belin Fund. Image courtesy the National Gallery of Art, Washington.

Later Eighteenth-Century Art in France

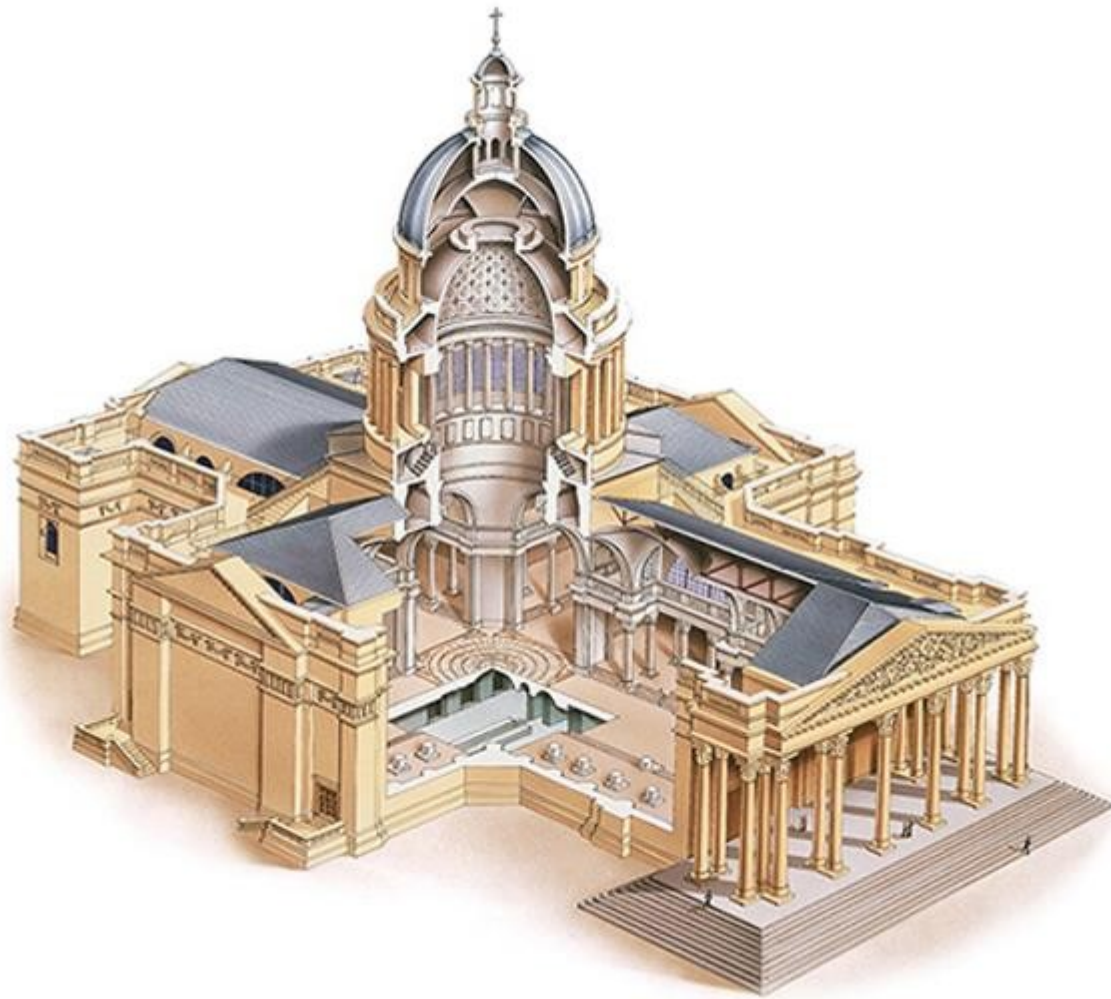
- The Enlightenment threw out the extravagance of the Rococo style.
- French art and architecture held closer to Classical styles as the Neoclassical movement took hold.

Architecture

- Jacques-Germain Soufflot's Panthéon exemplifies the Neoclassical style of architecture in Paris.
 - The building's ordered plan and sparse decoration reflect severity and simplicity.
 - Elements are drawn from ancient Roman temples, Wren's St. Paul's Cathedral, and Chiswick House.



Jacques-Germain Soufflot PANTHÉON (CHURCH OF SAINTE-GENEVIÈVE), PARIS
1755–1792.
JonRob/Fotolia.



CUTAWAY ILLUSTRATION OF THE PANTHÉON
© Dorling Kindersley.

Painting (1 of 8)

- Denis Diderot was a leading detractor of Rococo in the 1760s.
 - His *Encyclopédie* served as an archive of Enlightenment through France.
 - He believed that art's function was to "inspire virtue and purify manners" that Rococo could never satisfy.

Painting (2 of 8)

- Chardin
 - Jean-Siméon Chardin's *Saying Grace* illustrates a mother setting the table for a meal in front of her two children.
 - This genre painting extols the virtues of daily moral goodness in order to live a proper political and familial life.



Jean-Siméon Chardin SAYING GRACE
c. 1740. Oil on canvas, 19 x 15- $\frac{1}{8}$ " (49 x 38 cm).
Musée du Louvre, Paris. Photo © Musée du Louvre, Dist. RMN-Grand Palais/Angèle Dequier.

Painting (3 of 8)

- Greuze
 - Jean-Baptiste Greuze specialized in reflecting Diderot's *drame bourgeois* and "middle tragedy" through domestic genre paintings.
 - *The Village Bride* appeals to the notion that poverty and virtue can coexist.



Jean-Baptiste Greuze THE VILLAGE BRIDE, OR THE MARRIAGE, THE MOMENT WHEN A FATHER GIVES HIS SON-IN-LAW A DOWRY

1761. Oil on canvas, 36" x 46 1/2" (91.4 x 118.1 cm).
Musée du Louvre, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée du Louvre)/Franck Raux.

Painting (4 of 8)

- Vigée-Lebrun
 - Marie-Louise-Élisabeth Vigée-Lebrun's *Portrait of Marie Antoinette with Her Children* is in a more restrained style, depicting Marie Antoinette as a "good mother" despite her reputation.



Marie-Louise-Élisabeth Vigée-Lebrun **PORTRAIT OF MARIE ANTOINETTE WITH HER CHILDREN**
1787. Oil on canvas, 9'-1/2" x 7'-5/8" (2.75 x 2.15 m).
Musée National du Château de Versailles. © Jean Feuille/Centre des monuments nationaux.

Painting (5 of 8)

- David
 - Jacques-Louis David dominated French art for over 20 years during the French Revolution and reign of Napoleon.
 - *The Oath of the Horatii* was inspired by Pierre Corneille's drama, *Horace*, but the scene occurs neither in the drama nor any ancient text.
 - It became an ironic emblem of the 1789 French Revolution.



Jacques-Louis David OATH OF THE HORATII
1784–1785. Oil on canvas, 10'8-1/4" x 14' (3.26 x 4.27 m).
Musée du Louvre, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée du Louvre)/ Gérard Blot/Christian Jean.

Painting (6 of 8)

- David
 - *Death of Marat* depicts not the violent stabbing of Jean-Paul Marat, but the melodramatic aftermath.
 - Marat's pose implies that he was a martyr for the people.
 - David, a Jacobin, was arrested twice when the Jacobins lost power, but re-emerged during the height of Napoleon's ascendancy.



Jacques-Louis David DEATH OF MARAT
1793. Oil on canvas, 5'5" x 4'2-1/2" (1.65 x 1.28 m).

© Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium, Brussels. © Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium, Brussels/Photo: J. Geleyns - Roscan.

Painting (7 of 8)

- Girodet-Trioson and Labille Guiard
 - Anne-Louis Girodet-Trioson's *Portrait of Jean-Baptiste Belley* was a political statement.
 - The subject was a former slave who had led the campaign to abolish slavery in the colonies, particularly Saint-Domingue (now Haiti).



Anne-Louis Girodet-Trioson PORTRAIT OF JEAN-BAPTISTE BELLEY

1797. Oil on canvas, 5'2-1/2" x 3'8-1/2" (1.59 x 1.13 m).

Musée National du Château de Versailles. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (Château de Versailles)/Gérard Blot.

Painting (8 of 8)

- Girodet-Trioson and Labille Guiard
 - Adélaïde Labille-Guiard petitioned for the entry of women into the French Academy in 1790.
 - Her *Self-Portrait with Two Pupils* was submitted to the Salon of 1785.
 - The only male in this painting is her father, shown in bust behind her canvas—a role usually designated for women.



Adélaïde Labille-Guiard SELF-PORTRAIT WITH TWO PUPILS

1785. Oil on canvas, 6'11" x 4'11-1/2" (2.11 x 1.51 m).

Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Gift of Julia A. Berwind, 1953 (53.225.5).

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Sculpture

- Houdon
 - Jean-Antoine Houdon was commissioned to make the portrait statue of *George Washington* to be installed in the Virginia state capitol building.
 - The sculpture dresses Washington in modern clothes, but poses him in a Classical manner.



Jean-Antoine Houdon GEORGE WASHINGTON
1788–1792. Marble, height 6'2" (1.9 m).
State Capitol, Richmond, Virginia.

Spain and Spanish America

- Spanish artists did not embrace Neoclassicism with as much enthusiasm as the Baroque style.
- Court painter Francisco Goya shaped art at the end of the eighteenth century.
- Colonial art and architecture intermingled Spanish Baroque with the traditions of native peoples.